

[DRAFT] Southeast Conservation Adaptation Strategy (SECAS)

Landscape-Scale Impacts

Last updated: 7/30/2024

Overview

The Southeast Conservation Blueprint is the primary product of SECAS. As a spatial plan to inform collective conservation action and investment, the Blueprint is also the core way the partnership makes landscape-scale impacts. So far, the Blueprint is helping more than 400 people from [over 180 organizations](#) bring in new funding and inform their conservation decisions. That includes Blueprint uses in all 15 states and two territories within the SECAS region. The Blueprint has helped bring in over \$190 million in conservation funding to help protect and restore over 300,000 acres.

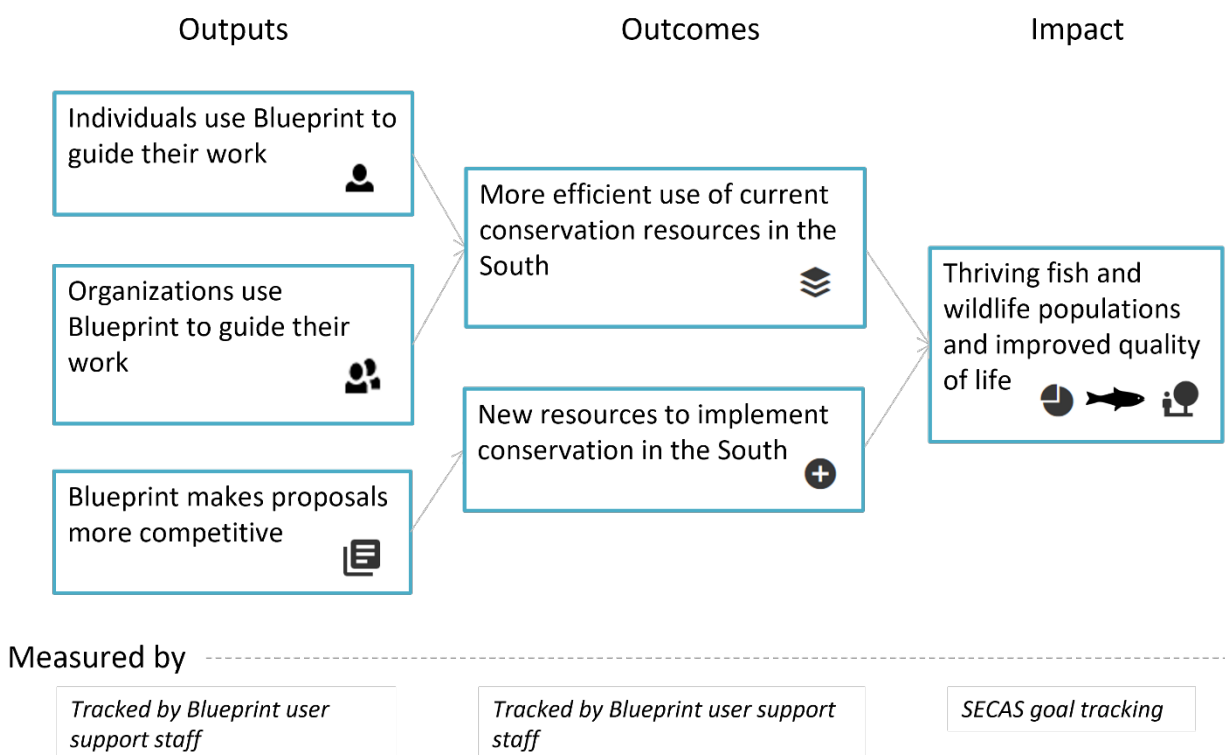


Figure 1. A simple logic model showing how uses of the Southeast Conservation Blueprint result in progress toward the SECAS vision and goal.

Examples of the Blueprint in action

Excerpts from an update to the [SECAS in Action story map](#) that will be available soon

State fish and wildlife agencies use the Blueprint to inform their Wildlife Action Plans

Fish and wildlife agencies for at least nine states and two territories (GA, KY, MS, SC, NC, LA, AR, TN, OK, PR, USVI) are using the Southeast Conservation Blueprint to inform ongoing updates to their State and territorial Wildlife Action Plans (SWAPs). SWAPs guide each agency's strategic conservation efforts to support species of concern known as Species of Greatest Conservation Need (SGCN). SWAPs represent an amazing repository of science, expert opinion, and collaboration with partners and the wider public. They also provide a framework for fish and wildlife agencies to coordinate with their neighbors to conserve species and their habitats regionwide.

Many of these state and territorial agencies are combining the Blueprint with other state and local data to identify or refine their Conservation Opportunity Areas (COAs). COAs are specific geographies that, due to the presence and condition of key habitats, are particularly important for SGCN. They also serve as focus areas to rally partners around collective conservation action. As a consistent regional plan, the Blueprint is helping fish and wildlife agencies better align their COAs across state lines.

In addition, SECAS staff are also helping some agencies write an additional chapter for their SWAPs. These chapters highlight how each state or territory contributes to the regional landscape, drawing on existing resources like the Blueprint and its underlying connectivity analysis, the [SECAS goal report](#), [plant and animal Regional SGCN](#), climate resilience and adaptation information, and areas important to key partners and regional partnerships. They also help increase consistency of SWAPs across jurisdictions and introduce a landscape-level perspective. These chapters help each agency not only support their own SGCN, but also consider priorities they share with other states to find new ways to work together.

To learn more about SECAS is helping support SWAP updates, [visit this blog](#).

The Blueprint supports conservation and the military mission

Over the last two decades, the military and conservation communities have increasingly found [common ground](#) in the Southeast. Urban growth and habitat loss threaten not only fish, wildlife, and working lands, but also hinders military testing and training activities by encroaching on buffers, obstructing key air space, and isolating rare species on bases. This intersection between natural resources and national defense has emerged as a theme in SECAS' work as partnerships in this nexus increasingly look to the Blueprint to provide a landscape-scale perspective.

The [Southeast Regional Partnership for Planning and Sustainability](#) (SERPPAS) incorporated the Blueprint into their "Good Map" depicting the priorities of many different partners. SERPPAS brings together leaders from the Dept. of Defense with representatives from Federal and State agencies for natural resources and working lands in NC, SC, GA, FL, AL, and MS. In addition, planning efforts in FL and NC involving several different branches of the armed forces have used the Blueprint to map important areas for conservation and military readiness in the face of climate change and urban growth.

The Blueprint has also helped strengthen three successful applications to establish Sentinel Landscapes in the SC Lowcountry, Northwest FL, and Eastern NC. [Sentinel Landscapes](#) are defined geographies anchored by at least one military installation or range that contain priority lands for conservation, working lands, and national defense interests across the Depts. of Defense, Agriculture, and Interior. The goal is to facilitate partnerships, make these key landscapes more competitive for Federal funding, and connect landowners with programs to keep working lands working (e.g., voluntary tax reduction programs, agricultural loans, technical aid, conservation easements).

Finally, in the [sustainability plan for Robins Air Force Base](#), developed in partnership with the Middle GA Regional Commission, the Blueprint helped identify priority natural areas in need of conservation within a 10-mile buffer surrounding the base. To learn more, [read this blog about SECAS military collaborations](#) and [this blog about supporting the designation of the SC Lowcountry Sentinel Landscape](#).

The Blueprint helps local governments plan for growth and expand recreation access

While urban growth is often considered a threat to conservation goals, it also represents an opportunity to collaborate with communities who want to grow sustainably, protect their natural resources, and ensure their residents have access to green space. Working with the Catawba Regional Council of Government, SECAS staff have helped several city and county governments in upstate SC incorporate the Southeast Blueprint into their planning documents, better aligning local actions with a regional strategy.

In one example, the Town of Fort Mill, SC used the Blueprint to help identify natural resource priorities in their 2040 comprehensive plan, which will guide efforts to conserve habitat, expand outdoor recreation opportunities, envision future land use, and mitigate development impacts. The Blueprint and underlying indicators also helped recommend conservation actions to undertake within these focus areas, such as promoting connectivity, controlling invasive species, and restoring riparian buffers.

In addition, the town of Sandy Springs, GA used the Blueprint to strengthen a grant proposal that brought in \$3 million from the GA Outdoor Stewardship Program. The project is protecting land through conservation easements and expanding outdoor recreation opportunities by extending a multi-use trail network. The Blueprint and underlying connectivity analysis helped town staff speak to the project's ecological value and its contribution to regional corridors.

For more information about how SECAS has worked with local planners in upstate SC, [visit this blog on the SECAS website](#).

The Blueprint helps bring America the Beautiful funds to the Southeast

In 2022, the White House launched a new funding initiative called the [America the Beautiful Challenge](#) intended to support and accelerate locally led efforts to conserve and restore land, water, and wildlife across the country. In the first two years of that program, SECAS helped support 27 proposals, nine of which were successful, bringing almost \$25 million to the Southeast! The SECAS Executive Steering Committee identified grasslands restoration and aquatic connectivity as regional priorities for this new funding source, so staff particularly emphasized support for proposals focused on those two issues.

The successful proposals included two planning projects—one to support the Eastern Band of Cherokee Indians in developing an integrated ecological management plan for their homeland in western NC, and one for the Southeastern Grasslands Initiative to develop a grassland conservation plan for the Cumberland Plateau ecoregion across KY, TN, GA, and AL. The remaining proposals funded on-the-ground conservation action by Tribes, state wildlife agencies, and their partners that will improve ecosystem health, function, and connectivity on more than 170,000 acres across 12 states and territories. This work will restore and connect glades, grasslands, and prairies; remove aquatic barriers like dams and culverts; increase prescribed fire; implement nature-based solutions for riparian restoration; and more.

SECAS will continue helping partners strengthen future proposals for America the Beautiful funding by using the Blueprint to demonstrate projects' regional significance, linking actions to the SECAS Goal, and showing alignment with the partnership's overarching priorities.